



The Five-Part Soul Question

The Shinma concept of a soul is that of a unitary whole that is simultaneously in five parts. To their sight, all souls behave this way, regardless of how other cosmologies may envision or interact with them. Shinma sorcery is no less effective on the most quintessentially-American tourist than it is on a rice farmer born and raised in the most rural and traditional of villages in Asia.



recognize five aspects of every soul, each aligned to one of the elements, that govern thought, emotion, and behavior. Just as their alchemical magic allows them to influence the world around them, it allows them to influence the souls of humanity.

The wood soul gives a person their emotions, passions, hopes, and dreams. It correlates with the Attributes of Appearance and Strength.

The fire soul controls a person's conceptions of propriety and behavior, and correlates most strongly with the Attributes of Charisma and Wits.

The earth soul gives rise to wisdom, insight, and understanding. It is best represented with the Intelligence Attribute.

The metal soul empowers a person's sense of justice and honesty, correlating with Dexterity and Perception.

The water soul represents faith (both in other people and in the greater universe), confidence, and fidelity. Its core attributes are Manipulation and Stamina.

The Art of Wu Tan

Creating an effect with Wu Tan is a singular act of will and focused Chi, and is represented by a dice pool. The dice pool is formed by combining the level of the I Chih being used with the relevant Attribute and the appropriate Chi value, Yin or Yang depending on the nature of the effect. Some effects are purely centered in Yin or Yang, and must use that Chi value. As it requires complete focus, a Wu Tan action cannot be combined with another action.

The difficulty of any Wu Tan roll is equal to (10 – the Chi value being used in the effect). For example, if a character's Yang Chi is 3, Yang effects carry a difficulty of 7.

By default, Wu Tan effects are limited to the character from which they originate, or those things she is touching directly. However, through the use of modifiers (below) she can extend the effect outward and change its nature. To use modifiers, the Hsien's player must allocate dice from her dice pool for the roll she wishes to influence, one per level of modifier. Whatever dice are left over once she has made her selection represent her final dice pool, and only these dice are actually rolled. Any successes on this roll beyond the first may be allocated to modifiers, if the player wishes to further amplify or extend the effect.

MODIFIERS

The following modifiers allow Hsien to alter the scope of Wu Tan effects, making them more powerful, farther reaching, longer lasting, and so forth. Unlike the Realms of the Kithain, modifiers do not need to be purchased — all Hsien have free access to them.

- ⑤ **Abundance** controls the number of people or objects the Hsien can manipulate with Wu Tan. Without this modifier's use, she can only affect herself! The first die allows her to affect one other person; the following dice expand that number (see Modifiers table, p. 437).
- ⑤ **Circumstance** allows the Hsien to set conditions to trigger her effect or to cancel it. The first die allocated allows her to set a common trigger, one respecting supergroups or large divisions — men or women, day or night, etc. Two dice narrows the field — a specific hour for the effect to take place, or a certain group, such as elected officials. Three dice allocated narrows the condition to total specificity, with perfect timing being possible and specific individuals being valid triggers for effects.
- ⑤ **Continuance** extends the duration of the effect, from a single turn with the expenditure of a single die to years and even decades with the expenditure of many more (see Modifiers table, p. 437).
- ⑤ **Domain** extends the range of an effect. Without it, the Hsien must touch her target. With a single die, she can affect anyone within a room, or generally speaking, within a little more than arm's length. Two dice allows her to target a small building, or anyone she might be able to reach at a dead run within a turn. Three dice lets her target someone or something within a large building such as a skyscraper or an entire village, and four lets her extend her reach across a city. Higher degrees of allocation extend her reach across entire provinces, perhaps across all of Asia for a sufficiently-herculean effort (and with Storyteller permission).
- ⑤ **Degree** combines degree of alteration and potential for harm — after all, what is harm but a violent and undesired change? Each die, therefore, may buy a die of damage for an effect intended to harm another. Spent to alter rather than merely destroy, the metric changes. A single die is enough to alter emotions if used on a soul, or make minor changes such as causing a flower to bloom — something that could plausibly happen without the Hsien's interference. Two dice may affect deeper-seated passions, or make significant, but still plausible, changes in the world — freshly planted seedlings might spring up into juvenile plants in seconds. Three dice allocated alters perception itself, or twists a patch of grass into a flower bed. With four dice, the psyche itself may be molded like clay, and truly spectacular changes can be conducted — the grass in our example doesn't just turn into a patch of flowers, but a fully grown and mature tree. Further dice allocated allow truly magnificent change, the stuff of Heaven itself, defying description by mere mortals. With this level of control, even elemental souls may be

